

COLONIAL UNREST

Before the Revolutionary War began in the spring of 1775, tensions had been building between Great Britain and its 13 American colonies for some time. The rift started shortly after the end of the French and Indian War (1754–1763), when Great Britain and American colonies fought against France and its American Indian allies.

The British and Americans eventually won the war, but the victory came at a steep price. The war had been very expensive, and it put a heavy strain on Great Britain's budget. The nation was already struggling with a soaring national debt due to costly wars with other European rivals. In addition, King George III now felt he needed to station British troops in North America. The king thought the colonies had to be

The French and Indian War was a costly war for the British government. It also increased tensions between American Indians and British colonists.

protected from the French settlers who remained in North America. He also feared attacks by American Indians, who may have been holding a grudge after the French and Indian War. Paying these North American troops added to Great Britain's money troubles, putting the country even further in debt. The king had a plan to lower his country's spiraling debt. He would tax the colonies.

SOURCES OF CONFLICT

The colonists did not want British soldiers guarding the colonies, and they certainly did not want to pay for them. Most Americans viewed the British troops as an armed force that could be ordered to turn against the colonists at any time. Colonists were also frustrated by Great Britain's ban on westward expansion. After the French and Indian War, many Americans wanted to settle in the Ohio River valley on the western frontier beyond the Appalachian Mountains. But the British Parliament feared settlers' westward movement would spark costly conflicts between colonial settlers and the American Indians who had lived in the Ohio River valley for centuries. With the Proclamation of 1763, King George banned colonists from settling west of the Appalachians. The ban angered many colonists.

Then came a wave of unpopular taxes levied against the colonies by the British Parliament. One of the Parliament's most hated actions was its adoption of the Stamp Act in March 1765. The Stamp Act applied a sales tax to paper products used for legal documents, newspapers, pamphlets, and cards.

NORTH AMERICA IN 1763

The treaty that ended the French and Indian War in 1763 left France with no territory in mainland North America. Great Britain got all of Canada, and as a result, Canada became a major staging area for British troops early in the American Revolution. Great Britain also ended up with nearly all North American territory east of the Mississippi River.

COLONISTS FIGHT BACK

The Stamp Act sparked outrage throughout the colonies. Most colonists believed the British Parliament did not have the right to tax them. These colonists argued that since they did not elect anyone to Parliament, they were being taxed without representation. They saw this as a violation of British law. Colonists protested against the Stamp Act, making the slogan “no taxation without representation” the focus of their outrage.¹

They threatened British agents who had been assigned to collect the tax.

Governing bodies in the colonies, known as assemblies, fought back as well. Virginia's colonial assembly passed a law stating it was the only governing body that could tax Virginians. Other colonial assemblies soon passed similar laws. In October 1765, representatives from nine of the colonies met in New York and issued a Declaration of Rights and Grievances. The document laid out the colonies' arguments against the taxes. It claimed Great Britain did not have the authority to tax the colonies because colonists were not represented in Parliament. It was the first time the colonies had banded together in a major joint action.

The tension between the British Parliament and the colonists only grew worse. Merchants in New York began boycotting British-made goods. The boycotts soon spread to Boston and Philadelphia. The British economy relied heavily on selling Great Britain's manufactured goods in the colonies, and the boycotts soon paid off. In March 1766, under pressure from the colonies, the Parliament repealed the Stamp Act. However, at the same time, it passed the Declaratory Act. This act declared Parliament had the legal authority to fully govern the



Colonists in Boston protested the Stamp Act.

colonies, including forcing them to pay taxes. Many colonists were outraged.

One year after passing the Declaratory Act, the British Parliament passed additional tax laws called the Townshend Acts. Under the Townshend Acts, imported goods from Great



King George III was king of Great Britain
and Ireland from 1760 to 1820.

Britain were taxed, including glass, paint, cloth, paper, and tea. Protests erupted in the colonies almost immediately. These protests were even more vigorous than those over the Stamp Act. The colonies formed groups to organize and enforce boycotts against all British goods covered by the taxes. The boycotts were so effective that by 1770 Parliament repealed all taxes on British-imported goods except tea.

BOSTON: THE HUB OF PROTEST

There was no place in colonial America where the protests against British taxes were as vocal and heated as Boston. Great Britain responded by sending troops to Boston to keep the peace. But sending soldiers only made the situation worse. Many Bostonians saw the soldiers' presence as a military occupation of their city.

Matters got even worse on March 5, 1770, when a mob of colonists attacked the British military barracks. The colonists were armed with rocks, clubs, and other weapons. When the colonists provoked the British soldiers, the soldiers fired on the crowd. When it was over, five colonists lay dead in the snowy street. Many other colonists were injured. Americans across the colonies were furious. Prominent Massachusetts political figures John Hancock and Samuel Adams led the colonial criticism of the shootings. Adams immediately labeled the confrontation the Boston Massacre.

Tempers flared once again in June 1772, when the British navy sent the *Gaspee* to patrol the Rhode Island coastline, looking for colonists who were smuggling goods into America without paying taxes on them. This did not sit well with the colonists. The citizens of Rhode Island did not want to pay



The Boston Massacre caused the rift between Great Britain and its American colonies to grow even wider.

taxes, and they felt the British had no right to patrol colonial waters. On the night of June 9, the *Gaspee* ran aground near Providence, Rhode Island. Colonists boarded the ship, subdued the crew, and burned the vessel. King George was furious about the incident. He ordered that those responsible for the attack

be captured and brought to Great Britain for trial.

The thought of Americans being put on trial in Great Britain alarmed many colonists. Samuel Adams proposed the colonial assemblies establish committees of correspondence. This would allow colonial assemblies to communicate with one another, through letters, about the actions that should be taken against threats to American liberties.

The American colonies were beginning to think about banding together to defend themselves against the British. But it would take one more incident, again in Boston, to incite the colonists to finally take up arms and fight for independence.

FATHER OF THE REVOLUTION

Samuel Adams was one of the earliest supporters of the Revolutionary War. Born in Boston, Adams came from a wealthy and politically active family. His second cousin, John Adams, would become the second president of the United States. Having failed in business as a young man, Samuel Adams turned to politics. As early as 1764, Adams opposed the British Parliament's plans to tax the colonies. He labeled the taxes a violation of colonial rights. Adams raised the point that the Parliament could not tax the colonies because the colonies had no representation in Parliament. He organized boycotts and demonstrations against the British taxes. He wrote letters to the other colonies, urging them to protest British taxation as well.

